

Case Studies and Stories - Human Impact Evidence

These case studies are fictionalized composites based on repeated themes found across many public submissions and national data sources. They show how rising costs and economic pressures affect everyday people. No individual story is used. All details are anonymized.

CS1 - The Rent Jump That Changed Everything

Overview: Rent rising faster than wages can destabilize even steady households.

Context: A family of four renting a home in the Southeast.

Story: For years, this family lived in the same house and always paid on time. Then a new owner raised the rent by \$400 at once. They tried to find another place nearby, but prices had risen everywhere. They cut groceries and savings but still fell behind. Finally, they moved to a smaller apartment far from work and school.

Data Connection: This reflects national data showing rent burdens rising faster than wages.

Why This Matters: It shows how one rent increase can push families into instability.

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CS2 - When Childcare Costs More Than a Paycheck

Overview: High childcare costs often push parents out of the workforce.

Context: A two-parent household with two young children in the Midwest.

Story: After their second child was born, a parent prepared to return to work. But childcare for two kids cost more than their paycheck. When their car needed repairs, working no longer made sense. The parent quit their job, and the family lost half its income.

Data Connection: This matches labor data showing childcare often costs more than rent.

Why This Matters: It shows how high prices reduce parents ability to work.

Verification Note: This case study is a fictionalized composite based on themes that appear across many submissions. No individual's story is used.

CS3 - One Emergency Visit, Months of Debt

Overview: Medical bills can create long-term debt even for insured workers.

Context: A single worker living in the Northeast.

Story: They visited the emergency room with serious pain. Treatment helped, but bills arrived later from the hospital and an out-of-network doctor. Insurance covered little due to a high deductible. The total cost was more than two months of income. They used a credit card and now face growing interest.

Data Connection: This reflects national patterns showing medical debt as a major burden.

Why This Matters: It shows how one medical event can disrupt financial stability.

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CS4 - Working Harder, Falling Behind

Overview: Even full-time workers struggle when pay does not keep up with prices.

Context: A resident with two hourly jobs in a Western state.

Story: This worker has two jobs: warehouse shifts on weekdays and delivery driving on weekends. Two years ago, this covered their needs. Now rent, groceries, and utilities cost more. A small raise did not cover inflation. They use credit cards for gas and feel worn down.

Data Connection: This mirrors data showing real wages failing to keep pace with inflation.

Why This Matters: It highlights how having a job is not the same as achieving financial stability.

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CS5 - The Commute That Costs Too Much

Overview: Cheaper housing often means higher transportation costs.

Context: A family of three living in the Southwest.

Story: They moved 40 miles away from the city to save on rent. But long commutes doubled their gas costs. Their car needed repairs from the extra miles. Insurance rates rose. The money they saved on rent was spent on transportation instead, and losing the car put their jobs at risk.

Data Connection: This reflects national data showing that transportation costs have surged.

Why This Matters: It shows how housing and transportation pressures combine to trap families in new expenses.

Verification Note: This case study is a fictionalized composite based on themes that appear across many submissions. No individual's story is used.

CS6 - The Hidden Cost of School

Overview: School supply lists and fees strain family budgets.

Context: A single parent with two children in the Mid-Atlantic region.

Story: School supply lists now include pricey items and technology fees. Buying everything would mean skipping the electric bill. Field trip and sports fees added more strain. The parent had to tell their children they could not join activities they enjoyed.

Data Connection: This matches data showing rising school-related costs.

Why This Matters: It shows how hidden fees limit opportunities for children.

Verification Note: This case study is a fictionalized composite based on themes that appear across many submissions. No individual's story is used.